

JKBOSE 2026

CLASS 11TH

POEM: THE LABURNUM TOP

LECTURE-1

ENGLISH

HUSSAIN SIR



Topics To Covered

1 ... Poem (Labour num Top) detailed explanation .

2 ...

3 ...

4 ...

The Laburnum Top *Ted Hughes*

The Laburnum top is silent, ^{without movement} quite still →

In the afternoon yellow September sunlight,

A few leaves yellowing, all its seeds fallen.

The poet describes a laburnum tree that is silent and still under the yellow light of the September sun. The tree's leaves are turning yellow, and its seeds have fallen, suggesting the arrival of autumn and a kind of lifelessness.



Laburnum: a short tree with hanging branches, yellow flowers and poisonous seeds

Yellow September sunlight: Autumn sunlight, symbolic of fading life

Yellowing: Turning yellow, a sign of age or autumn

Seeds fallen: Indicating the end of the flowering season

QUESTION



What time of the year is described in the beginning of the poem?

- 1** September (Autumn)
- 2** Winter
- 3** Spring
- 4** Summer

The Laburnum Top *Ted Hughes*

Till the goldfinch comes, with a twitching chirrup
A suddenness, a startlement, at a branch end.
Then sleek as a lizard, and ^{alive} alert, and abrupt, ^{nest}
She enters the thickness, and a machine starts up
Of chitterings, and a tremor of wings, and trillings —
The whole tree trembles and thrills.

The scene comes to life when a goldfinch (a small yellow bird) arrives. She makes chirping sounds and moves swiftly and suddenly like a lizard. As she enters the tree, it suddenly seems to come alive with noise and movement — the chicks inside the nest start chittering, flapping their wings, and trilling, making the whole tree vibrate with energy.

Goldfinch: A small yellow-and-black songbird

Twitching: Sudden small movements

Startlement: A sudden feeling of surprise

Sleek: Smooth and glossy

Tremor: A small shaking or quivering movement

Trillings: Repeated high-pitched bird sounds

Thrills: Gets filled with excitement or emotion



QUESTION

What happens to the laburnum tree when the goldfinch comes?

- 1 It becomes dry
- 2 It becomes noisy and lively ✓
- 3 It falls down
- 4 It remains still

QUESTION



How does the poet describe the movement of the goldfinch?

1 As lazy and slow

2 As calm and quiet

3 As abrupt and lizard-like ✓

4 As hesitant and fearful

The Laburnum Top *Ted Hughes*

^{→ Goldfinch}
It is the engine of her family.

She stokes it full, then flirts out to a branch-end

Showing her barred face identity mask

The goldfinch is described as the engine of her family (her young chicks). She feeds them ("stokes it full"), and after completing her duty, she flutters out to the edge of a branch, showing her distinctive striped face, which is like her identity mask

Engine of her family: The one who keeps the family going (the mother bird)

Stokes: Adds fuel to keep something going (feeds the chicks)

Flirts out: Moves quickly and playfully

Barred face: Face with patterns or stripes

Identity mask: Unique facial pattern that identifies the bird

QUESTION



What does the phrase "engine of her family" refer to?

- 1 Goldfinch's nest
- 2 Her chicks
- 3 The tree
- 4 The goldfinch herself ✓

The Laburnum Top *Ted Hughes*

Then with ^{strange} eerie delicate whistle-chirrup whisperings
 She launches away, towards the ^{sky} infinite
 And the laburnum subsides to empty.

After feeding her chicks, the goldfinch flies away with a soft and mysterious whistle. As she departs into the infinite sky, the tree once again becomes silent and still, returning to its lifeless state.

Eerie: Strange and mysterious

Delicate: Gentle and soft

Whistle-chirrup: A soft combination of whistle and chirping sounds

Launches away: Flies off swiftly

Infinite: Endless sky or space

Subsides: Becomes quiet or still again

Empty: Without life or sound again

QUESTION

What happens to the laburnum top after the goldfinch leaves?

- 1 It bursts with color
- 2 It catches fire
- 3 ~~It becomes still and silent again~~
- 4 It falls down

QUESTION



What kind of sound does the goldfinch make while flying away?

- 1 Loud and harsh
- 2 Deep and musical
- 3 ~~Eerie and delicate whistle-chirrup~~
- 4 Sharp and metallic

QUESTION



What is the central theme of the poem?

- 1 Loneliness and sorrow
- 2 ~~Power of motherhood and vitality in nature~~
- 3 Destruction of trees
- 4 Man vs nature

Theme of the poem

The poem reflects the contrast between stillness and activity, life and barrenness. The laburnum tree seems lifeless until the goldfinch arrives and brings vibrancy and energy to it. It highlights the beauty of nature, the bond of motherhood, and the cyclic nature of life.

Poetic Devices



Alliteration

“September sunlight”

Repetition of the 's' sound

Personification

“a machine starts up”

The tree is described as if it becomes alive like a machine

Simile

“sleek as a lizard”

Compares the bird's movement to that of a lizard

Metaphor

“engine of her family”

Goldfinch is compared to an engine (without using 'like' or 'as')

Poetic Devices



- Onomatopoeia:** “chitterings”, “chirrup”, “trillings” Words imitate the sounds made by birds
- Enjambment:** Whole poem One line flows into the next without punctuation, creating a smooth rhythm
- Imagery:** “The whole tree trembles and thrills” Vivid image of the tree's transformation
- Symbolism:** Laburnum tree Represents lifelessness which turns vibrant with the arrival of life (goldfinch)

QUESTION



What do you notice about the beginning and the ending of the poem?

ANSWER:

At the beginning of the poem, the laburnum tree is silent, still, and seemingly lifeless, bathed in the yellow light of September. At the end of the poem, after the goldfinch flies away, the tree returns to the same state of emptiness and silence. This cyclical structure shows how the presence of the bird brings temporary life and energy to the tree.

QUESTION



To what is the bird's movement compared? What is the basis for the comparison?

ANSWER:

The goldfinch's movement is compared to that of a lizard—"sleek as a lizard". The basis of this comparison is the bird's sudden, smooth, alert, and sharp movements, much like how a lizard swiftly darts or slips around with quick motions.

QUESTION



Why is the image of the engine evoked by the poet?

ANSWER:

The image of the engine is evoked to symbolize the energy and vitality that the goldfinch brings to the tree. Just like an engine powers a machine, the bird activates the nest, filling it with chitterings, movements, and life. The metaphor highlights the mother bird's role as the driving force of her family.

QUESTION



What do you like most about the poem?

ANSWER:

I like the way the poet contrasts stillness and activity, showing how the arrival of a tiny bird can transform a lifeless scene into a vibrant one. The use of vivid imagery and sound words makes the scene come alive. Also, the symbolism of nature's quiet strength and motherhood is beautifully expressed.

Thank
You